

Pragmatic Analysis of Fayose's Counsel to Fubara

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Abstract

Statements made by politicians are not to be taken on their face value, in that they bear the depth of meaning that is hardly understood by a layman. The counsel of Mr. Ayo Fayose, to Amaopusenibo Siminalayi Fubara, is one of such. Mr. Fayose, during a banquet organized in honour of the immediate past governor of Rivers State, prophesied, in the manner of advice, that any attempt by Fubara to “see more than you should see, you will begin to see spirits”. Employing a qualitative methodology and H.P. Grice's Theory of implicature, the paper examines the layered meanings, and the communicative intent embedded in the utterance. Findings reveal that the speaker used implicature as a tool for subtle persuasion, indirect warning, and face-saving revelation thereby flouting some cooperative principles. It is recommended that politicians be direct and state point blank whatever information they wish to pass to their listeners for easy understanding.

Keywords: Pragmatic, analysis, implicature, Fayose, Fubara

Introduction

Language in political discourse often carries multiple layers of meaning, requiring careful interpretation to uncover intended messages. Politicians and public figures frequently employ implicature to express opinions without making explicit claims, allowing for plausible deniability. Given the political tension surrounding the candidature and election of the addressee, Amaopusenibo Siminalayi Fubara, the present governor of Rivers State, and the influence of his political “godfather”, Chief Barrister Nyesom Ezenwo

Wike, in the state and the nation at large, analyzing this utterance through the lens of implicature exposes the rhetorical power and strategic ambiguity in which political statements are wrapped.

More often, political discourse involves implied meanings that serve different purposes, including persuasion, warning, or positioning within power structures. Language users, particularly in political contexts, tend to avoid direct confrontation while still ensuring that their messages are passed. This practice is especially prevalent in societies where direct statements may have significant repercussions. By leveraging implicature, politicians can communicate effectively while maintaining a level of diplomatic ambiguity. The chosen statement reflects the political landscape in which it was made, where subtlety and indirectness are crucial.

There is no limit to what language can do or what politics can do using language. Players in the arena of politics understand that one of the most important tools they have is language and they use it in such a way that makes or mars their ventures. As Opeibi (2003) observed, whenever political actors in and out of government communicate about political matters for political purposes, political discourse crops up. Language can have a profound impact on our perceptions, attitude and beliefs.

In every sphere of life, more especially politics, language transcends mere communication, it is a powerful instrument of influence, persuasion and control. The words and phrases used to describe political issues, events, or ideologies deeply affect our thinking and reactions. As Adama (2020) averred, it is generally known that politicians make utterances that are embedded in underlying meanings. They mean more than they say.

Different theorists, scholars, and critics have offered their opinion on the role of language in shaping political realities, with some holding tenaciously to the neutrality of language in political discourse, while others seriously contend that language plays a very active role in constructing and reinforcing power relations. However, the notion that language is neutral has been challenged by critical linguists who argued that language is always embedded in social and cultural context where its meaning and usage are shaped.

Also, some scholars have argued that language can be described in different levels, that is, the syntactic, semantic, stylistic, and rhetorical levels. Stating

further that it can be understood in terms of the interlocutor's processes of production, reception and understanding. The statement under analysis can be examined through any of the levels. People want to be understood when they speak, it is as Ngulube (2022) put it, that the intention to communicate something to somebody is why people speak, and that it is the foundation of all linguistic behaviour; politicians are not exception.

It becomes imperative to always examine the linguistic strategies and discourse structures into which political communication is woven, in order to unpack the meaning, power dynamics and ideological assumptions embedded in a public discourse as such. It is important also, to bear in mind the fact that language does not only reflect reality, it is also an active participant in influencing our understanding of the world and our place within the world.

Globally, and particularly in Nigeria, political rhetoric is often permeated with cultural metaphors that reflect the relationship between tradition and modern politics. It is imbued with indirect warnings, which highlight the complexities that exist between language and political maneuvering. Mr. Ayo Fayose's statement represents a case in point: it is not only a personal admonition to Amaopusenibo Siminalayi Fubara, but also a broader communicative strategy prevalent in Nigerian politics. The speech serves as both a cautionary message and a demonstration of power dynamics, political rivalry and "godfatherism" prevalent in the Nigerian political landscape.

This study aims at demonstrating how pragmatic elements in political discourse contribute to broader sociopolitical schemes. To understand these elements, analyzing how implicature shapes political narratives and influences decision-making processes is required. One of the interesting problems to be studied in linguistics is implicature in political discourse, in that politicians use sentences which imply something different from the literal meaning (Khairat 2016).

This paper examines the pragmatic implication of the statement of Mr. Ayo Fayose, former governor of Ekiti State, Nigeria, addressed to Amaopusenibo Siminalayi Fubara, the present governor of Rivers State, Nigeria, during the banquet organized in honour of chief Barrister Nyesom Ezenwo Wike, the immediate past governor of Rivers State and incumbent Minister of the Federal Capital Territory (FCT).

Objectives of the Study

The objectives of this study are to:

1. Analyze the use of implicature in the political advice under review.
2. Examine how the speaker flouted or adhered to Grice's cooperative principles in his advice.
3. Explore the use of religious and metaphorical language used in this political advice.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative approach. The selected statement is analyzed using Grice's conversational implicature framework, focusing on the four maxims of quantity, quality, relation, and manner. The data was collected from a national daily, and interpreted to identify implicit messages and their pragmatic effects. Though the statement was made in 2023, for the sake of this study, the data was retrieved from the publication of *The Cable* 2025, when it transcended into a reality.

Theoretical Framework

This paper adopts Grice's theory of implicature. Researchers have shown that time was when some philosophers of language viewed language as purely a linguistic issue, which was why its analysis focused on giving a detailed account of a particular language phenomenon. Grice then came up with theory of implicature with the aim of analyzing language beyond linguistics to showing how standard it can be used and how it can be used by speakers in their speech.

Grice (1975, p. 44) averred that implicature is “the indirect or implicit meaning of an utterance that is produced by the speaker”. Implicature, as conceptualized by Grice (1975), distinguishes between what is explicitly stated and what is suggested. It serves as an essential tool in communication, allowing speakers to imply meanings beyond the literal interpretation of words.

It is one of the instances of linguistic phenomenon, an additional meaning indicating an aspect of pragmatic influence (Levinson, 1983). The author opined further that: (1) the theory of implicature has the ability to provide a functional explanation of the facts of language which are not covered by the structural linguistics (2) it gives an explanation that is explicit regarding the differences between what is said and what is implied (3) different semantic

clause relations can be described by the use of conjunctions through the theory of implicature, and (4) it has the ability to explain literally, different linguistic elements which appear unrelated or opposite to each other but can be actually associated.

Implicature can also be seen as an implied proposition by an utterance of a sentence in a context, even though the proposition may not be part of, or the entailment of what was said, (Gazda 1978, cited in Samson et.al., 2024). They continued that implicature is inherent in every conversation in that there is an assumption that the listener has a background knowledge of the discourse. Shardimgaliev (2019) opined that implicature is a piece of information that a speaker communicates indirectly, that is, without making the conveyed information explicit, and that success in communication is dependent upon shared expectation of interlocutors.

The theory of implicature was developed with the aim of systematically accounting for utterances that go beyond their surface meanings, that is, what Ikehukwu-Ibe & Ezebube (2020, p. 36) defined as “the act of meaning one thing by saying something else...”. What it means is that implicature probes deeper into the meaning of utterances in order to discover what semantics refers to as the *unsaid said*. To corroborate the above assertion, it is stated in Grice's theory that implicature explains the meaning of the expressions which may not be resolved by the semantic theory.

Grice (1975) identified two forms of implicature – conventional implicature and conversational implicature. According to the author, conventional implicature has to do with the conventional meaning of words used to determine what is implied. Thus, the derivation of meaning does not depend on any specific context in this type of implicature. As Yule (1996) put it, there are specific words with which conventional implicature is associated which convey additional meaning when used.

On the other hand, implicature is conversational when “what a speaker means or implies is different from what he says”, (Grice 1975, cited in Samson et al. 2024). According to the literature, the essence is to provide a clear difference between what someone says and what he implies. One can conclude that Conversational implicature refers to meanings that arise not from the explicit content of an utterance but from the context. Conversational implicature is

interested in analyzing how language is used in utterances, that is, the direct words of a speaker and how the hearer derives meaning from it, (Samson et al. 2024).

Conversational implicature is of two types, that is, generalized conversational implicature (GCI), and particularized conversational implicature (PCI). In Grice's opinion, GCI is one that requires no specific knowledge of context in order to derive the conveyed meaning; while PCI is one that requires specific context for meaning to be derived. One is the direct opposite of the other.

Scholars always build on existing theories for the advancement of knowledge. This has brought about some contributions and further development of this theory. Besides the types of implicature developed by Grice, other types of implicatures such as: scalar implicature, short-circuited implicature, politeness implicature, speaker implicature, sentence implicature have been arrived at.

According to Yule (1996), scalar implicature centres on terms such as: many, most, all, often, few, always, some, sometimes; which express some values. These words express some value scale in a conversation and can be selected, in that they are considered most informative and honest.

Short-circuited implicature was coined by Morgan (1977), that it is a form of implicature which the hearer arrives at without calculation. Leech (1983) defined politeness implicature as one that has to do with the observation that politeness may arise when something is implied. Haugh (2002) argued that politeness implicature arise when something is implied in addition to what has been said.

Whereas speaker implicature, according to Davis (2005) is arrived at when a speaker says one thing and means another. The determining factor of this type of implicature is intention. The type of implicature which depends on the community's speech convention is known as sentence implicature. Davis (2005) argued that sentence implicature is dependent upon the convention of the speakers' language community.

Grice's theory of implicature is rooted in what is called the Cooperative Principles, where he believed that discourse participants have conversation aim they want to fulfill at the moment, and advises that the achievement of that

aim or goal should be the focus of the conversation. That conversation participants should keep their contribution appropriate to the trajectory agreed upon.

He identified four maxims which interlocutors should typically adhere to to facilitate effective communication. These maxims are: quantity, quality, relation, and manner. The maxim of quantity holds that one's contribution should be as informative as possible, and not more informative than required. The maxim of quality holds that a speaker doesn't say that which they lack evidence. The contribution should be true and not give information they know to be false. It means that what a speaker says must be backed up by sufficient evidence that is deeply rooted in truth.

While the maxim of relation has to do with relevance; that is the contribution should be relevant to the conversation; and the maxim of manner which is the final talks about avoidance of obscurity. This maxim looks beyond the content of the information, and focuses on how the information is presented. Grice used the phrase 'be perspicuous' to advise that participant should uphold these four sub-maxims: avoid ambiguity, disorderliness, and there should be brevity.

However, it has been established that speakers may also flout these maxims strategically to achieve specific communicative goals, such as persuasion, caution, or indirect criticism, and this is where implicature arises.

Data Presentation and Analysis

excerpt:

Your excellency, my counsel to you: God will help you. Don't see more than what you should see. The moment you want to see more than you should see, you will begin to see spirits. I know Wike. If he says he will fight you, it is either you surrender or you look for the trouble to the end. God will not give you Wike's problem. (The Cable, 2025)

Analysis

In this statement, multiple layers of implicature are employed. Breaking the entire statement down to phrases and or clauses, one may understand that the statement is imbued with indirectness. The statement starts with *Your Excellency*, implying that the stool of the addressee is political, powerful and respected by the addresser. The phrase, *my counsel to you*, has the implication that the addressee needed guidance on how to navigate the murky waters of

politics. However, the counsel, first metamorphoses into religious invocation: *God will help you*, which serves a dual purpose: it provides reassurance while also framing the situation as beyond human control. This strategic use of implicature allows the speaker to convey caution without making explicit accusations, maintaining diplomatic subtlety while issuing a strong advisory message.

Rather than delivering a simple counsel, Fayose delves into an elaborate message that sounds more cryptic than necessary, thereby flouting the maxim of quantity. The implicature is that there is more danger than the eyes can see.

The sentence, *Don't see more than what you should see*, implies a warning, advising the recipient against overstepping boundaries. There is nothing wrong in seeing, but everything will be wrong if he decides to see *more*. The idea that, *seeing more* leads to *seeing spirits* metaphorically suggests that curiosity or excessive ambition can result in unforeseen consequences. It reminds one of the saying in our locality that: the less you see, the more peace you enjoy. Being curious may lead one into the journey of discovery, and consequences of which one may not have been prepared to bear.

Traditionally, whatever involves spirits is no longer temporal, and it takes divine intervention for solution to be proffered. One can assume from the statement without conceding, that there are certain things the addressee is not supposed to see, and other things that should not be given attention to. It is also implied that seeing those things could result in breaking relationship, because there could be political confrontation.

Spirits, in the Nigerian world-view, are not only feared, but also beyond human control. They have the ability to hunt people and harm them, and they can also be consulted for judgement. Therefore, seeing spirits may not be a good omen in this case. Notwithstanding, not all spirits are malevolent, some are benevolent, but seeing spirits here implies that he could see what he would not be able to handle.

The maxim flouted here is the maxim of manner. This maxim holds that the speaker should be as clear as possible. However, the speaker wraps his caution in metaphor making it difficult for a layman to understand if what would be seen is a benevolent or malevolent spirit. The statement is vague and ambiguous. However, the implicature remains that there will be dire

consequences if Fubara oversteps.

Even though the addresser, no matter how much he knows Wike, could not reveal what amounted to seeing more than the addressee should see, he says, *I know Wike*. The question is, how? Does he know Wike as one who would contribute meaningfully to the addressee's administration? Or he knows Wike as one who would mar his administration? The reference to Wike establishes a pragmatic implication of political confrontation.

The phrase, *If he says he will fight you*, indirectly implies that Wike can overlook certain things if he hasn't decided to venture into it and that his decision is final. *it is either you surrender or you look for the trouble to the end*, implies that he does not just pick a fight, he will make sure that it ends in his favour or you surrender. In fact, the addresser implies that Wike is a formidable opponent, reinforcing the speaker's warning about potential conflicts. The statement suggests that the best the addressee should do would be to allow sleeping dog lie – avoid whatever would bring altercation between you and Wike as the only thing that would douse Wike's determination would be to see opponents completely defeated.

The speaker added, *God will not give you Wike's problem*, subtly suggesting that engaging with Wike would be a significant burden, one that the recipient should seek to avoid. This religious invocation reinforces the projection that, in case conflict arises, which could be as a result of Fubara venturing into “seeing more than he should see”, only God would be the solution provider, not any other being, but God Himself.

The maxim of quality is partially flouted. The reason is that Fayose said things that are based on what he believes and on exaggeration, instead of verifiable truth. Saying *God will not give you Wike's problem* is more of a prayer than a statement of fact. The implicature is that Wike is a problem only divine intervention can prevent or solve.

The maxim of relevance is not flouted. This is because everything said is highly relevant to the political context and relationship between Wike and Fubara. Findings reveal that personalized conversational implicature (PCI) was strategically used to navigate a sensitive topic, encode indirect message, and to avoid direct confrontation. Van Dijk (2006), and Ayasreh and Razali (2018)

opined that political figures rely more often on PCI to navigate sensitive topics that require contextual knowledge for the implied meaning to be grasped. The reason for flouting these maxims (quantity, manner, and quality), are not far-fetched, in order to avoid open confrontation with Wike, fayose was subtle in handling his advice to Fubara, as he made it look like the former was a demi-god. That is, Fayose wrapped the advice in praise that suggested how formidable Wike could be.

The use of implicature helped the speaker to distance himself from any negative outcome, yet emphasizing the need for Fubara to remain in political loyalty to the one who supported him to win election and be returned as governor of the oil rich state. Like Franke et al (2020) argued, political discourse often employs ambiguity in such a way that helps politicians to avoid direct commitment. It may not be out of place to conclude that Fayose foresaw the political tension that would likely arise if the addressee ignored the advice. It is what may be referred to as unconscious prophecy or foreshadowing in literature.

Furthermore, it is revealed that Fayose knew more about the political landscape of the state and country than Fubara, on the one hand; and knew Wike as not only the predecessor of Fubara but also as one who would stop at nothing to achieve his aim. The adviser was once a governor, he had the knowledge about political relationships and how “godfatherism” works in Nigeria - being loyal to your political godfather is non-negotiable.

In Nigeria, the intention of most political predecessors' in supporting their prospective successors to win election is on the ground that they would do their (the predecessors') biddings without questioning. It is a way of remaining in power in proxy, thereby making their successors “title holders” but do not allow them to enjoy the powers with which the title is saddled.

Without mincing words, it is in the nature of human beings to break away from control and that whatever involves two or more individuals, misunderstanding is inevitable. At one time or another, it will come. Fayose understood this and was timely about his warning. There is also a possibility that he might have experienced such attitude from a political “godson”, or exhibited same to his political “godfather” and in both cases, the experience might not have been a good one. So he would not wish it to a loved one, hence

his warning.

At the same time, Fubara may want to govern independently as the one in charge, and on that process may discover some shoddy deals from previous administration, including his godfather's, the advice of Mr. Fayose should always re-echo in his sub-consciousness. Consequently, to avoid "seeing spirit" it is wise to see less, or keep mute even when more have been seen.

Finally, it was revealed that even politicians need God's help. As it could be seen from Mr. Fayose's advice, the only being that would solve the problem, if it arises would be God and not man, and what would cause the curiosity of Mr. Fubara not to arise would be prayers – *God will help you ... God will not give you Wike's problem*. The advice may be short and simple but it is loaded with implicature and the reason for that is to persuade, indirectly warn, and do a face-saving revelation. Politicians have the penchant for wrapping their statements in ambiguity and indirectness.

Conclusion and Summary

This analysis demonstrates how implicature enables politicians to communicate powerful messages without making explicit claims. The speaker employs conversational implicature to issue warnings, suggest political prudence, and subtly caution against unnecessary confrontation. By flouting Grice's maxims, the speaker enhances rhetorical effectiveness while maintaining a very good relationship with both Fubara and Wike.

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